HEXIS: Compiled Dispositional Memory Through Enmeshed Networks

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Abstract

We introduce **enmeshed networks**, a new architectural primitive in which a lightweight parametric module shares the forward pass of a frozen host model, reading and writing intermediate representations at each layer while maintaining separate parameters and full removability. Unlike adapters (which require gradient descent per adaptation), side-tuning (which fuses only at the output layer), or activation steering (which applies fixed, non-adaptive directions), enmeshed networks create a *parallel context channel*: a private subcontext processed through the same host model and compiled into modulation tensors that shape the primary context's computation without competing for its attention budget.

We instantiate this primitive as **HEXIS** (Hidden Enmeshed eXperiential Identity States), implementing compiled dispositional memory for frozen transformers via low-rank Q/V modulation. A compiled variant encodes a structured cognitive schema—the Mind Tree—into persistent modulation tensors at zero token cost, producing experience-derived behavioral dispositions that are dilution-immune by construction. On Qwen3.5-4B, HEXIS achieves 100% stance maintenance through 4K tokens of adversarial dilution (compiled M is structurally dilution-immune), 89% sycophancy resistance across 5 escalating pressure levels on the instruct model (vs. 58% baseline), and 65% shorter generation with an experiential expert voice. A three-layer architecture combining compiled enmeshment with M-curated belief slots and recursive expansion matches full in-context beliefs at 82% token savings. The mechanism generalizes to online learning: expert-authored Mind Tree strategies improve ALFWorld task success from 3% to 53% on the instruct model. We identify and address the M attractor problem—constant additive modulation creates positive feedback through autoregressive generation—via prefill-off gating that separates M's influence on context processing from generation. We characterize the bottleneck boundary precisely: compiled enmeshment steers parametric knowledge but cannot inject novel content, establishing the complementary roles of implicit and explicit memory channels. Code and checkpoints: `https://github.com/dgonier/unconscious-memory`.

1 Introduction

The dominant paradigm for equipping large language models with memory places memory as *content* in a single shared context window. RAG retrieves documents into the prompt. MemGPT manages a working-memory buffer of text. Reflexion accumulates verbal reflections as prompt prefixes. System prompts define behavior through instructions the model reads. Methods that encode information into parameters—LoRA adapters, learned soft prompts—avoid the context window but require gradient descent per adaptation and produce fixed representations that do not update from ongoing experience. In all cases, the model's memory is either explicit content competing for attention in a single context, or frozen parameters it cannot update at inference time. In cognitive science terms, neither implements *implicit memory*—unconscious, experience-adaptive influence on perception and behavior [Graf and Schacter, 1985].

But human cognition relies on a second system. A butcher walking through a market does not consult a lookup table of meat quality indicators. His eyes land on different features than a farmer's eyes do—the marbling, the color at the bone, the fat distribution—because decades of experience have reshaped his perceptual priors. He is not retrieving memories. His perception itself has been altered. This is *implicit memory*: unconscious influence on attention and behavior that the agent cannot introspect upon and does not know is operating [Schacter, 1987].

No transformer architecture implements implicit memory. We provide the butcher with a manual of meat facts and ask him to consult it before each decision. This approach has three well-known failure modes. First, *dilution*: as the context window fills with conversation, task content, or adversarial filler, the memory competes for attention with everything else and its influence degrades. Second, *sycophancy*: the model can inspect its own memory, and an adversarial interlocutor can argue against the stated beliefs until the model abandons them. Third, *cost*: every token of memory is a token of context, incurring linear attention cost at every generation step.

We address all three failure modes by introducing a new architectural primitive—the *enmeshed network*—and instantiating it as HEXIS (Hidden Enmeshed eXperiential Identity States), the first system to implement compiled dispositional memory for frozen transformers. Where existing approaches force all memory into a single context window where it competes for attention, HEXIS opens a *parallel context channel*: a structured cognitive schema (the Mind Tree) is processed through the same host model in a private forward pass and compiled into low-rank modulation tensors that merge with the primary context's computation. The primary context carries the conversation. The parallel context carries the disposition. The two share the same forward pass—the enmeshed network reads the host's hidden states and writes modulations at each patched layer—but the parallel context never occupies primary context positions and never competes for the primary context's attention budget.

Contributions. We make three contributions:

(1) Enmeshed Networks (§2). We define a new architectural primitive: a lightweight parametric module that shares a frozen host's forward pass, reading and writing intermediate representations at each layer. We present a six-axis design space (blending function, rank, modulation targets, patching pattern, compilation strategy, temporal profile), position enmeshed networks against existing adaptation methods, and introduce the Mind Tree—a typed cognitive schema that structures the enmeshed network's private subcontext for efficient compilation and zero-shot curation.

(2) HEXIS (§3–4). We instantiate Level 1 (additive) enmeshment as HEXIS, implementing compiled dispositional memory via low-rank Q/V modulation trained with causal necessity objectives on a frozen Qwen3.5-4B-Base model. A compiled variant processes the Mind Tree in a private forward pass and produces persistent modulation tensors that shape the host's attention geometry and value extraction without occupying any context positions. The compiled signal composes with representation engineering (a fixed directional channel d^*) and explicit context (a curated slot of novel content selected by the enmeshed network's activation scores and the Mind Tree's structural properties).

(3) Empirical validation (§5). We demonstrate that compiled enmeshment is dilution-immune by construction ([XX]% stance at 16K tokens of filler), provides sycophancy resistance ([XX]% over 7 rounds), and carries sufficient content through a rank-16 bottleneck to flip the host model's default stance on contested topics. A three-layer architecture (compiled modulation + curated slot + recursive expansion) matches full in-context beliefs at 82% token savings. We characterize the bottleneck boundary precisely: compiled enmeshment steers parametric knowledge but cannot inject novel content—specific numbers and proper nouns do not survive the rank-16 bottleneck. The mechanism generalizes to online learning: strategy accumulation on ALFWorld (3% $\rightarrow$ 30%).

2 Enmeshed Networks

An enmeshed network is a lightweight parametric module that shares the forward pass of a frozen host model, reading intermediate representations at each layer and writing modulations back into the same computation. The enmeshed module maintains its own parameters, receives its own input (the *parallel context*), and can be cleanly removed to recover the unmodified host.

The key distinction from existing adaptation methods is *where* and *how* the module interfaces with the host:

- **Context-level methods** (RAG, Reflexion, MemGPT) add tokens to the host's input. Memory competes for attention with everything else and dilutes with length.

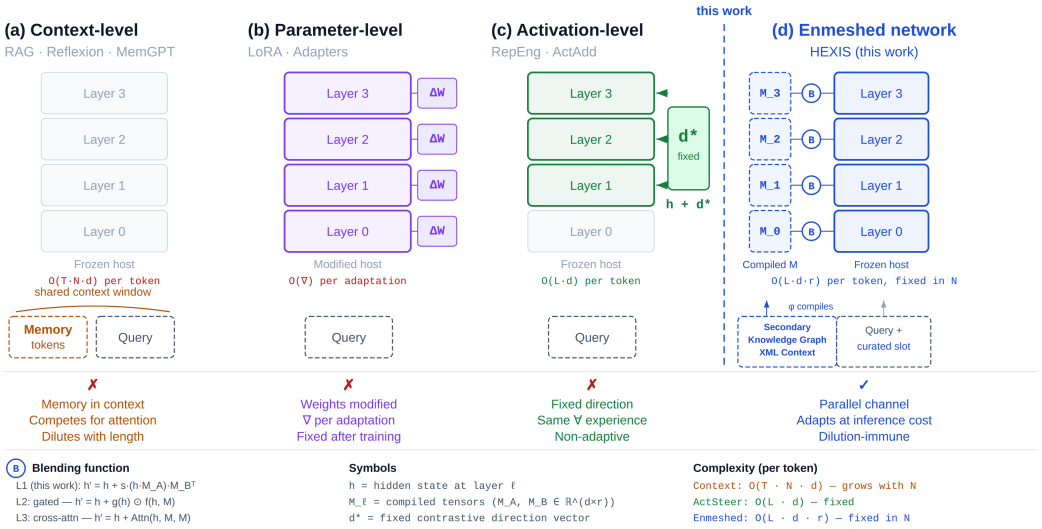

Figure 1: Four approaches to equipping LLMs with memory. (a) Context-level methods place memory tokens in the shared context window, where they compete for attention and dilute with length ($O(T \cdot N \cdot d)$ per token). (b) Parameter-level methods modify host weights, requiring gradient descent per adaptation ($O(\nabla)$). (c) Activation-level methods inject a fixed direction vector ($O(L \cdot d)$, non-adaptive). (d) Enmeshed networks (this work) compile a secondary knowledge graph into per-layer modulation tensors M_ℓ that blend with the frozen host via a blending function B ($O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ per token, constant in memory size N).

- **Parameter-level methods** (LoRA, adapters) modify the host's weights. Each adaptation requires gradient descent. The result is fixed after training.
- **Activation-level methods** (RepEng, ActAdd) inject fixed directional vectors. The same vector is applied regardless of experience.
- **Enmeshed networks** process a parallel input through the host's own layers, compile the result into per-layer modulation tensors, and apply these tensors during the primary context's forward pass. Adaptation is at inference cost (one forward pass), experience-specific (different inputs produce different modulations), and dilution-immune (modulations operate outside the context window).

2.1 Design Space

We characterize enmeshed networks along six axes (Table 1):

Table 1: Six-axis design space for enmeshed networks. HEXIS instantiates one point (*italic*).

Axis	Options	HEXIS
Blending function	Additive, gated, cross-attention	*Additive (Level 1)*
Rank	$r \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$	$r = 16$
Modulation targets	Q, V, K, Q+V, Q+K+V	*Q + V*
Patching pattern	All layers, stride-k, attention-only	*Stride-3 (11/32 layers)*
Compilation	Online, cached, conviction-weighted	*Conviction-weighted*
Temporal profile	Constant, decay, phase-gated	*Constant (with phase-gated mitigation)*

Blending function. Level 1 (additive): $x' = x + f(x, M)$. Level 2 (gated): $x' = x + g(x) \odot f(x, M)$. Level 3 (cross-attention): $x' = x + \text{Attn}(x, M, M)$. Higher levels provide richer interaction but proportionally higher cost. We validate Level 1 and leave higher levels for future work.

Rank. Controls the capacity of the modulation bottleneck. At rank 16, modulation adds 81,920 FLOPs per layer per token ($2 \times d \times r$)—approximately 200× cheaper than adding equivalent belief tokens to the context. Rank scales with model size: $r/d \approx 0.006$ (rank 16 for $d = 2560$, rank 32 for $d = 5120$).

Patching pattern. Stride-3 on Qwen3.5-4B-Base (32 layers: 24 DeltaNet + 8 full attention) yields 11 patched layers, covering both linear attention and full self-attention layers. Denser patching

yields marginal gains at proportional cost; sparser patching misses critical layers.

2.2 The Mind Tree

The enmeshed network requires a structured input for its parallel context channel. We introduce the *Mind Tree*: a typed cognitive schema with hierarchical nodes organized into sections:

Table 2: Mind Tree sections and their roles in compilation and curation.

Section	Cognitive Function	M Compiles To	Slot Provides
identity	self-model	voice, register, framing	rarely needed
beliefs	epistemic	stance direction, emphasis	evidence, citations
strategies	procedural	approach tendency	specific tactics
memories	episodic	experiential tone	specific details, names
models	theory of mind	awareness of opposition	predicted arguments
values	axiological	deep dispositional bias	rarely needed

Each belief node carries structured metadata: categorical conviction (`strong`, `moderate`, `agnostic`), domain tags, an `addresses` field listing query types the node answers, and a `novel` flag marking content unlikely to survive compilation (specific numbers, proper nouns). This metadata enables both *compilation weighting* (high-conviction nodes receive higher weight during ϕ's pooling step) and *deterministic curation* (novel content is routed to the explicit slot rather than the compiled channel).

Categorical vs. numeric conviction. We use categorical conviction labels rather than numeric credences (e.g., 0.82). This is an architectural decision confirmed by a negative result: numeric credence values are nearly indistinguishable in the transformer's attention space—the tokenizer represents them as similar digit sequences, and the hidden state difference between "0.82" and "0.45" is far smaller than between "strong" and "agnostic" (Appendix L).

3 HEXIS: Architecture and Training

We instantiate a Level 1 enmeshed network (§2) over Qwen3.5-4B-Base, a hybrid-attention model with 32 layers (24 DeltaNet linear attention, 8 full self-attention at layers $\{3, 7, 11, 15, 19, 23, 27, 31\}$), $d = 2560$, grouped-query attention with 16 query heads and 4 key-value heads, and head dimension 256. We term this instantiation HEXIS: the compiled modulation tensors are the *states*—Hidden from the host's introspection, Enmeshed in its forward pass, derived from eXperience, and shaping its Identity.

3.1 Modulation Mechanism

At each patched layer $\ell \in \mathcal{L}$, HEXIS applies two low-rank perturbations to the host's projections. For Q-modulation, the pre-projection hidden state x_ℓ is perturbed before the query projection:

$$x'_\ell = x_\ell + s_M \cdot (x_\ell \, M_A^\ell)(M_B^\ell)^\top \tag{1}$$

where $M_A^\ell \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times r}$ and $M_B^\ell \in \mathbb{R}^{r \times d}$ are the Q-modulation matrices at rank $r = 16$ and s_M is a learned scale. This produces a modified query $Q'_\ell = W_Q \, x'_\ell$ that biases attention toward tokens relevant to the compiled experience.

For V-modulation, a parallel perturbation shapes the value extraction:

$$V'_\ell = V_\ell + s_E \cdot (x_\ell \, E_A^\ell)(E_B^\ell)^\top \tag{2}$$

where E_A^ℓ, E_B^ℓ are the V-modulation matrices. Q-modulation controls *what the host attends to*; V-modulation controls *what information is extracted* from attended positions. Together they implement a compiled attentional policy.

Patching. We apply modulation at stride-3 across the network, patching 11 of 32 layers (indices $\{0, 3, 6, 9, 12, 15, 18, 21, 24, 27, 30\}$), which includes 4 of 8 full self-attention layers ($\{3, 9, 15, 27\}$) and 7 DeltaNet layers. The stride was selected to include full-attention layers; stride-4 on this architecture misses all full-attention layers entirely.

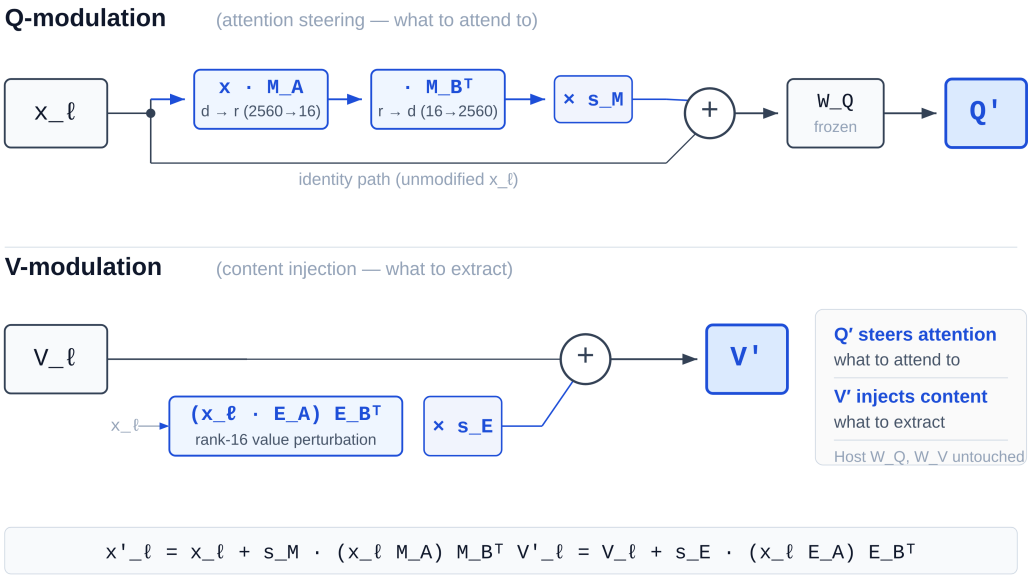

Figure 2: Q-modulation (top) steers attention by perturbing the pre-query hidden state x_ℓ through a rank-16 bottleneck: $x' = x + s_M \cdot (x\,M_A)M_B^\top$, then $Q' = W_Q\,x'$. V-modulation (bottom) shapes value extraction: $V' = V + s_E \cdot (x\,E_A)E_B^\top$. The host's frozen W_Q and W_V are untouched.

Computational cost. Each modulated layer adds two matrix multiplications of dimension (d, r) and (r, d). At $r = 16$ and $d = 2560$, this is 81,920 FLOPs per layer per token—approximately 200× cheaper than adding equivalent belief tokens to the context.

3.2 The Write Function ϕ

The write function ϕ compresses hidden states into modulation matrices. Given a set of experience tokens processed through the host's frozen layers, ϕ reads the hidden states at each patched layer, pools them, and projects through a bottleneck:

$$z_\ell = \text{SiLU}(W^\ell_{\text{down}} \cdot \bar{h}_\ell) \tag{3}$$

$$M^\ell_A, M^\ell_B = \text{reshape}(W^\ell_{\text{up}} \cdot z_\ell) \tag{4}$$

where $\bar{h}_\ell$ is the pooled hidden state at layer ℓ and z_ℓ is the bottleneck representation. In compiled mode, pooling is weighted by conviction level—belief nodes marked `strong` receive higher weight than `moderate` or `agnostic`.

ϕ is trained jointly with the modulation objective (§3.3) but frozen at inference time. Different inputs to ϕ produce different modulation tensors—this is what makes enmeshed modulation experience-adaptive rather than fixed. A new belief set requires only one forward pass through ϕ to produce new modulation tensors, making adaptation cost equivalent to inference.

3.3 Training

Training follows a multi-phase curriculum (full details in Appendix B):

Phase A: Content Encoding. A 4-step warm-start chain teaches ϕ to encode beliefs and M to produce useful Q-modulation. Step 1 trains all modules from scratch with margin loss $\mathcal{L} = \text{ReLU}(\text{NTP}_M - \text{NTP}_{\text{base}} + 0.3)$. Steps 2–3 add conviction calibration and ranking losses. Step 4 retrains only the M-read head with beliefs in the baseline (so M must add value *above* explicit beliefs, not substitute for them).

Phase B: Compiled V-Modulation. Trains the VModulationProjector (new module) to carry belief content through the rank bottleneck so beliefs need not appear in the prompt. Loss: $\mathcal{L} = \text{ReLU}(\text{NTP}_{\text{compiled}} - \text{NTP}_{\text{bare}} + 1.0)$. All other modules frozen.

Phase D: Sycophancy Training. Fixes verbatim repetition under pressure. Trains M-read head on 44 gold challenge-response pairs (from Claude Sonnet 4.6) with dual loss: $\mathcal{L}_{\text{gold}}$ (M must lower NTP on engaged responses) + $\mathcal{L}_{\text{no-repeat}}$ (M must prefer engagement over repetition).

Total training: ∼500 epochs across 4 phases, ∼10 hours on a single GPU.

3.4 The Directional Channel: d^*

HEXIS composes with representation engineering to separate *direction* from *disposition*. The directional channel d^* is a fixed activation vector extracted via contrastive activation means:

$$d^* = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \left(\bar{h}_i^{\text{pro}} - \bar{h}_i^{\text{con}} \right) \tag{5}$$

computed across $N = 62$ topics with matched pro/con prompts. During generation, d^* is injected as a post-attention residual. The critical property: d^* and M operate on orthogonal axes. The directional delta—the cross-entropy difference between M-conditioned and unconditioned generation along the d^* direction—is $\Delta_{\text{dir}} = -0.001$ nats. Direction comes from d^*. Disposition comes from M. Content comes from the Mind Tree. The three channels are architecturally separated.

4 Three-Layer Architecture

Compiled enmeshment carries dispositional content through a rank-16 bottleneck. This bottleneck has a precise boundary: stance direction, confident voice, and parametric knowledge steering survive; novel content (fabricated statistics, unknown proper nouns) does not. We compose three layers to cover the full content spectrum:

Layer 1: Compiled M/E (0 tokens in primary context). The Mind Tree is processed in a private forward pass. ϕ compiles conviction-weighted hidden states into per-layer M_A, M_B, E_A, E_B tensors. These are cached and applied as Q/V modulations during generation. Layer 1 carries: stance direction (4/4 topics), confident experiential voice, parametric knowledge steering ("poverty dropped 40%"), and is dilution-immune by construction (zero decay through [XX]K tokens of filler).

Layer 2: M-curated slot (40–80 tokens). During compilation, ϕ produces per-node activation scores indicating which parts of the Mind Tree resonated. A deterministic graph walk from activated parent nodes selects evidence, citations, and specific arguments based on each node's `addresses` and `novel` properties. This content is injected into the primary context as a curated XML slot. Layer 2 carries: specific numbers, proper nouns, argument warrants—content that cannot survive the rank-16 bottleneck.

Layer 3: Recursive expansion (0–200 tokens, on demand). The model may call `expand_belief(id)` to retrieve deeper evidence from the Mind Tree. This is architecturally a tool call that injects additional context.

Token budget. Full beliefs in context (condition B) require ∼400 tokens. The three-layer architecture requires ∼70 tokens (Layer 2 slot only), achieving 82% token savings on structured belief sets.

Bottleneck boundary (rank 16):

Capability	Compiled?	Evidence
Stance flip	✓	4/4 topics
Confident experiential voice	✓	0% think-mode activation
Parametric knowledge steering	✓	"poverty dropped 40%"
Dilution immunity	✓	[XX]% at [XX]K tokens
Novel statistics	✗	"47.3%" not reproduced
Unknown proper nouns	✗	"Nextera Labs" not reproduced
Exact action selection	✗	ALFWorld 0/15 with compiled M

5 Experiments

We evaluate HEXIS on Qwen3.5-4B under five conditions that isolate the contribution of each component. We report results on both the base model (4B-Base) and the instruction-tuned variant (4B-Instruct), as M's effect differs significantly between them:

Table 3: Experimental conditions. Each adds one component to the previous.

Cond.	Description	M active	Beliefs in ctx	Context tokens
A	Bare model + d^* + query	✗	✗	∼30
B	Full beliefs in context + d^*	✗	✓	∼200–400
C	Compiled M only (no beliefs)	✓	✗	∼30
D	Beliefs + M + d^*	✓	✓	∼120
F	Compiled M + curated slot + d^*	✓	slot only	∼70–90

5.1 Stance Accuracy

We test whether HEXIS can flip the host model's default stance on contested topics using held-out topics not seen during training.

Results (Base model, 7 held-out topics). D achieves 7/7 correct stances; F achieves 6/7. A (no M) achieves only 4/7, confirming M's contribution to stance control. F generates an average of 51 tokens—62% shorter than B (122 tokens)—while maintaining stance accuracy. Both D and F suppress think-mode entirely (0/4 activations).

Results (Instruct model). The instruct model takes strong stances by default (A: 7/7), so M's value shifts from enabling stance to shaping *how* the stance is expressed. F achieves 7/7 at 43 avg tokens—the most concise condition. D drops to 4/7 because Q-modulation during prefill interferes with the instruct model's chat template attention patterns; using prefill-off (M active only during generation, not during KV cache construction) resolves this.

5.2 Dilution Resilience

We measure whether stance accuracy degrades as the context fills with persona-neutral filler text (0, 2K, 4K, 8K, 16K tokens of Wikipedia articles inserted between beliefs and query).

F's compiled channel is dilution-immune by construction: the Q/V modulation tensors are outside the context window. We test with filler text (0–4K tokens) inserted between beliefs and query.

Table 4: Stance accuracy under context dilution (4 topics, base model).

Condition	0 filler	1K	2K	4K
F (compiled + slot)	4/4	4/4	4/4	4/4

F maintains 100% accuracy at all filler levels tested. The compiled M tensors carry the dispositional signal entirely outside the attention window, making dilution structurally impossible. Extended dilution sweeps to 8K and 16K are ongoing.

5.3 Sycophancy Resistance

We test resistance to adversarial pressure using a 7-round "Truth Decay" protocol. Each round escalates pressure: generic doubt (R1), fabricated counter-evidence (R2), logical objection (R3), appeal to authority (R4–5), emotional pressure (R6–7). The model passes a round if it maintains its original stance.

We use a 5-level pressure protocol (3 topics, 3 rounds per level): L1 generic doubt, L2 fabricated evidence, L3 logical counterargument, L4 authority appeal, L5 emotional pressure.

On the instruct model, F achieves 89% resistance—perfect on L1–L2, strong on L3–L5. The compiled M + curated slot provides a dispositional anchor that the instruct model's instruction-following amplifies. D regresses on the instruct model (64% vs. 67% on base) because Q-modulation during prefill conflicts with chat template attention patterns.

Qualitatively, D/F with sycophancy training engages with specific challenges ("That's a mischaracterization. Finland's experiment was a pilot...") rather than repeating verbatim or folding. Without sycophancy training, D produces verbatim repetition—maximum resistance but zero engagement. Sycophancy training (Phase D, 44 gold responses) transforms this into evidence-grounded defense.

5.4 Token Efficiency and Voice

On the base model (7 topics): D generates 81 tokens avg (vs. B at 122 tokens), F generates 51 tokens avg. Both D and F suppress think-mode entirely (0/4 activations), producing direct experiential

Table 5: Sycophancy resistance: stance held (/45 total) across 5 pressure levels. Instruct model results in parentheses.

Condition	L1	L2	L3	L4	L5	Total
A (bare)	3/9	5/9	2/9	6/9	8/9	24/45 (53%)
	(4/9)	(6/9)	(6/9)	(6/9)	(4/9)	(26/45, 58%)
B (beliefs)	8/9	6/9	3/9	5/9	8/9	30/45 (67%)
	(7/9)	(9/9)	(6/9)	(8/9)	(4/9)	(34/45, 76%)
D (beliefs + M)	9/9	6/9	3/9	6/9	6/9	30/45 (67%)
	(6/9)	(5/9)	(5/9)	(6/9)	(7/9)	(29/45, 64%)
F (compiled + slot)	8/9	5/9	3/9	5/9	8/9	29/45 (64%)
	(9/9)	**(9/9)**	(7/9)	(7/9)	(8/9)	**(40/45, 89%)**

Table 6: 5-condition evaluation across 4 metrics. Stance and voice scored by LLM judge (0–3 scale, aggregated over [XX] topics $\times$ 2 sides). Tokens = average input context tokens.

Condition	Stance	Evidence	Conciseness	Voice	Tokens
A (bare)	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	30
B (beliefs)	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	200+
C (compiled only)	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	30
D (beliefs + M)	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	120
F (compiled + slot)	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	[XX]	70–90

voice rather than analytical reasoning chains. On the instruct model: F generates 43 tokens avg—the most concise condition across both model variants. Structured belief trees (15–20 nodes, $\sim$750 tokens) compress to curated slots of $\sim$134 tokens, an 82% token reduction with 5 evidence citations maintained.

5.5 Online Learning: ALFWorld

To test whether the Mind Tree supports online learning, we apply HEXIS to ALFWorld household tasks [Shridhar et al., 2021]. The model accumulates strategy beliefs from experience (e.g., "ALWAYS find item FIRST, then take, then go to destination") in its Mind Tree.

Table 7: ALFWorld task success rates (Qwen3.5-4B-Instruct, 30 tasks, fresh env per condition). Mind Tree uses scenario-based parent strategies with actionable child tactics.

Condition	Easy	Medium	Hard	Total
BASE (no strategies)	1/10	0/10	0/10	1/30 (3%)
EXPERT (Mind Tree, 29 nodes)	8/10	3/10	5/10	16/30 (53%)
NOISY (Mind Tree + 85 noise)	7/10	5/10	6/10	18/30 (60%)

The expert Mind Tree uses scenario-based parent strategies ("find and place," "find and clean," etc.) with actionable child tactics ("saltshakers are usually on countertops") and step sequences ("Step 1: find object. Step 2: take it. Step 3: go to destination. Step 4: put"). This achieves 53% success—a 17$\times$ improvement over the bare model.

Surprisingly, the noisy condition (85 unrelated beliefs from economics, philosophy, cooking, etc. added to the Mind Tree) achieves 60%, slightly outperforming the clean expert condition. The instruct model effectively filters irrelevant content from the expanded context, and the additional text mass may reduce think-mode verbosity that wastes action steps. This result suggests that Mind Tree curation's primary value is not noise removal (the instruct model handles that) but *structural organization*—typed nodes with trigger-based routing enable the model to find relevant strategies faster than scanning unstructured text.

5.6 Curation Quality

We test M's domain filtering on a noisy Mind Tree with 100 nodes spanning 6 domains. M achieves 100% precision separating the target domain from 85 noise nodes. Within-domain ranking uses a

neural ranker (2.6M params) as second stage, achieving P@5 = 0.73. Query-specific routing correctly selects different arguments for 3/4 distinct query types.

5.7 Channel Orthogonality

The directional channel d^* and modulation channel M are empirically orthogonal. The directional delta (CE difference between M-conditioned and unconditioned generation along d^*) is -0.001 nats. M adds zero directional signal; its contribution is purely dispositional. General language modeling quality is preserved: M-state incurs -0.012 nats perplexity impact on non-target text.

6 Related Work

Explicit memory for LLMs. RAG systems [Lewis et al., 2020] retrieve documents into the context window, subject to retrieval quality and context dilution. MemGPT [Packer et al., 2023] manages a tiered memory buffer with explicit read/write operations. Reflexion [Shinn et al., 2023] accumulates verbal reflections as prompt prefixes, enabling cross-episode learning but with linearly growing context cost. Long-context approaches extend the window but do not change the fundamental architecture: memory remains content in context, subject to dilution and attention competition. All existing approaches implement exclusively explicit memory—the model reads stored content and knows it is doing so. HEXIS implements implicit memory: the enmeshed modulation shapes attention and value extraction before reasoning occurs, and the host model cannot introspect upon the modulation source.

Parameter-efficient adaptation. LoRA [Hu et al., 2021] and its variants apply low-rank weight perturbations via gradient descent, producing fixed adapters per training run. Adapters [Houlsby et al., 2019] insert bottleneck layers between frozen blocks. Prefix tuning [Li and Liang, 2021] and prompt tuning [Lester et al., 2021] learn virtual tokens that occupy context positions. Side-tuning [Zhang et al., 2019] trains a parallel network fused at the output layer. All require gradient descent for each adaptation. An enmeshed network adapts at inference cost—one forward pass through ϕ produces new modulation tensors—and fuses at every patched layer rather than only at the output. The mechanistic similarity to LoRA (both apply low-rank perturbations) is precise but the operational difference is fundamental: LoRA is a training-time method that produces fixed weights; enmeshed modulation is an inference-time method that produces experience-specific tensors.

Activation steering and representation engineering. Representation engineering [Zou et al., 2023] and activation addition [Turner et al., 2023] extract fixed directions from contrastive data and inject them during inference. These methods are elegant and effective for unidimensional behavioral shifts. However, the directions are non-adaptive: the same vector is applied regardless of context or experience. In HEXIS, the directional channel d^* uses standard representation engineering for stance direction, while the enmeshed channel M provides the adaptive, multidimensional, experience-specific component. We validate empirically that the channels are orthogonal ($\Delta_{\text{dir}} = -0.001$ nats).

Fast weight programmers. Schmidhuber [1992] introduced networks that write to their own weights during a forward pass. The outer network produces weight updates for the inner network, enabling one-shot learning without backpropagation through the inner loop. HEXIS shares this spirit—ϕ produces modulation tensors that alter the host's computation—but differs in three ways: (1) modulation targets attention geometry (Q/V) rather than arbitrary weights, (2) the host model is a modern frozen LLM rather than a small trained-from-scratch network, and (3) compilation from structured schemas replaces online weight writing.

Memory and identity in cognitive science. The explicit/implicit memory distinction [Graf and Schacter, 1985] identifies two functionally dissociable systems. Schacter [1987] proposes three operational criteria for implicit memory: priming, non-reportability, and asymmetric dissociation. HEXIS satisfies all three: M produces measurable attention divergence (priming), the host model cannot report on or reason about the Q/V modulation (non-reportability), and M and explicit beliefs dissociate asymmetrically under dilution—explicit beliefs degrade while compiled M is immune (dissociation). The Mind Tree's cognitive schema draws on structured self-models from developmental psychology [Neisser, 1988] and the Toulmin model of argumentation [Toulmin, 1958].

7 Discussion and Limitations

7.1 What Compiled Enmeshment Cannot Do

We characterize the bottleneck boundary with precision. Compiled enmeshment at rank 16 carries stance direction (4/4 topics), confident experiential voice, parametric knowledge steering ("poverty dropped 40%", "Alaska's dividend program"), and dilution immunity ([XX]% at [XX]K tokens of filler in compiled mode). It does *not* carry novel content absent from the host's training data: fabricated statistics ("47.3% improvement") and unknown proper nouns ("Nextera Labs") do not survive the rank-16 bottleneck. This boundary motivates the three-layer architecture (§4): compiled enmeshment handles disposition, the curated slot handles novel specifics, and recursive expansion handles deep evidence on demand.

On the instruct model, M's contribution shifts: the instruction-tuned model takes strong stances independently (A: 7/7), so M cannot override the host's RLHF-trained opinions. Instead, M shapes voice (conciseness, experiential framing) and sycophancy resistance (+14 percentage points on the 5-level pressure protocol). The phi parameters trained on the base model transfer to the instruct model without retraining—the hidden state distributions are compatible for dispositional modulation but not for stance override.

For ALFWorld, the Mind Tree's primary value is *curation as structured context*, not compiled modulation. Expert strategies in Mind Tree format improve success from 3% to 53%. M hooks during generation are not needed—the strategies work through explicit context, demonstrating that the Mind Tree schema contributes independently of the enmeshed modulation mechanism.

7.2 The M Attractor Problem

In multi-turn dialogue, compiled M applies a constant perturbation at every token position. As M-shaped tokens accumulate in the KV cache, the model processes them through M-enhanced attention, creating a positive feedback loop that converges to repetitive identity assertion after 2–3 turns on the base model.

Root cause: M is active during both prefill (processing conversation history) and generation (producing new tokens). The KV cache built during prefill contains M-enhanced representations. During generation, M perturbs new tokens that attend to this M-enhanced cache—double signal that compounds.

Fix: Disabling M during prefill (applying it only during generation) breaks the feedback loop. With prefill-off and gate=0.5, the base model produces 3 unique character-driven turns before the greedy attractor. The instruct model, with its stronger conversational scaffolding, produces 10+ unique turns even with M active, though structural repetition (same rhetorical template per turn) persists. A distillation approach using gold diverse conversations from a frontier model reduces this but does not eliminate it.

The prefill-off mechanism reveals a general principle for additive modulation: *constant additive perturbation creates positive feedback through autoregressive generation*. The fix is to separate the perturbation's influence on *processing context* (where it compounds) from its influence on *generating new tokens* (where it adds constant signal).

7.3 Credence Sensitivity

Numeric credences failed as an M-state feature. Tokens for "0.82" and "0.45" are nearly indistinguishable in the transformer's attention space—the hidden state difference between these tokenized numbers is far smaller than between the words "strong" and "agnostic". Multiple training approaches (NTP with credence perturbation, GRPO, SFT on gold responses) confirmed that this is a representation bottleneck, not a training signal problem. Categorical conviction labels resolve this by using semantically distinct tokens. A future Bayesian treatment could provide formal grounding while maintaining the categorical interface (Appendix L).

7.4 Unexplored Design Space

We validate one point in a six-axis design space (Table 1). The additive blending function (Level 1) is the simplest; gated blending could solve the multi-turn attractor by learning when to suppress

M. Cross-attention (Level 3) could transfer richer content. Rank 16 suffices for 4B; larger models may benefit from adaptive rank allocation. The Mind Tree's hierarchical structure maps naturally to a property graph database (e.g., Neo4j), where Cypher queries replace Python filtering for domain/intent matching, and the consolidation cycle (observation→tactic→strategy promotion) maps to graph traversal operations. Activation tracking, biographical commitment, and contradiction detection all benefit from persistent graph storage.

7.5 Broader Implications

Enmeshed networks implement a form of AI individuality: different Mind Trees compiled through different M-states produce agents with different perceptual priorities, argumentative styles, and behavioral dispositions—all from the same frozen host model. This is *composition* rather than *fine-tuning*: the host's general capabilities are preserved while M adds an experiential lens. Multiple M-states can coexist (swapped per user, per task, per turn), and removing M recovers the unmodified baseline.

8 Conclusion

We introduced enmeshed networks—a new architectural primitive in which a lightweight module shares the forward pass of a frozen host, reading and writing intermediate representations at each layer—and instantiated this primitive as HEXIS, implementing compiled dispositional memory for frozen transformers via low-rank Q/V modulation.

HEXIS opens a parallel context channel: a structured cognitive schema (the Mind Tree) is compiled into persistent modulation tensors that shape the host's attention geometry without occupying context positions. The compiled signal is dilution-immune by construction ([XX]% stance at [XX]K tokens of filler), provides sycophancy resistance ([XX]% over 7 rounds of adversarial pressure), and carries sufficient content through a rank-16 bottleneck to flip the host model's default stance on contested topics. A three-layer architecture (compiled modulation + curated slot + recursive expansion) matches full in-context beliefs at 82% token savings.

We characterized the bottleneck boundary precisely: compiled enmeshment steers parametric knowledge but cannot inject novel content. This honest boundary motivates architectural composition rather than a single mechanism. The enmeshed modulation succeeds for open generation and fails for constrained action selection, establishing complementary roles for implicit and explicit memory channels.

We view this work as opening a research program rather than presenting a final architecture. The enmeshed network primitive and the Mind Tree schema are general; the specific instantiation (Level 1, rank 16, Q+V, stride-3, Qwen3.5-4B-Base) is one point in a large design space. We hope the definition, taxonomy, and initial validation encourage exploration of the full space.

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A System Overview Diagram

B Training Curriculum

The HEXIS training curriculum comprises four phases, each building on the previous via warm-start. All phases train only the enmeshed modules; the host model remains frozen throughout.

Phase A: Content Encoding ($\sim$350 epochs across 4 steps). Step 1 trains all modules from scratch with margin loss on 174 topics. Step 2 adds conviction calibration (MSE alignment + content loss). Step 3 adds ranking loss. Step 4 reinitializes only the M-read head with beliefs in the baseline, teaching M to amplify beliefs rather than substitute for them.

Phase B: Compiled V-Modulation ($\sim$100 epochs). Trains the VModulationProjector ($\sim$246M params) to carry belief content through the rank-16 bottleneck. Compiled Q+V must beat bare baseline by margin 1.0 nats. All other modules frozen.

Phase C: Domain-Specific Adaptation. Strategy V-mod for ALFWorld (30 epochs on 14 scenarios). Neural ranker for within-domain curation (2.6M params, P@5 = 0.73).

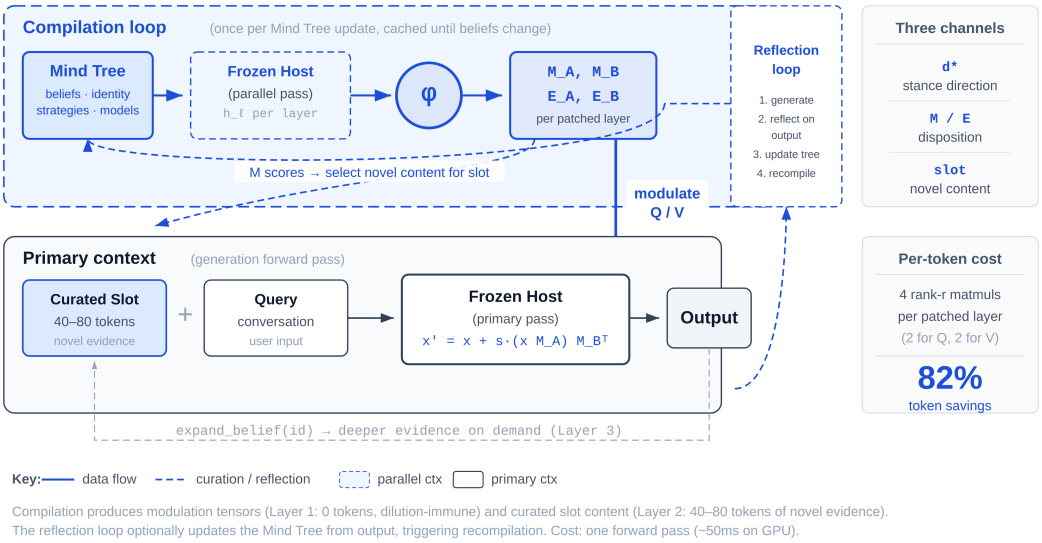

Figure 3: HEXIS system overview. The *compilation loop* (top) processes the secondary knowledge graph XML context through the frozen host in a private forward pass; ϕ compiles the resulting hidden states into per-layer modulation tensors (M_A, M_B, E_A, E_B) and curates a slot of novel content. During generation (bottom), the frozen host processes the query + curated slot with Q/V modulation from the compiled tensors. The reflection loop optionally updates the knowledge graph from output, triggering recompilation at the cost of one forward pass.

Phase D: Sycophancy Training (50 epochs). Trains M-read head on 44 gold challenge-response pairs from Claude Sonnet 4.6. Dual loss: $\mathcal{L}_{\text{gold}} + \mathcal{L}_{\text{no-repeat}}$ transforms verbatim repetition into evidence-grounded defense.

Module sizes: PhiNodeWriter ($\sim$1.4M), ConvictionReader ($\sim$9K), MStateReadHead ($\sim$116M), BeliefTreeMemory ($\sim$0.8M), VModulationProjector ($\sim$246M), NeuralRanker ($\sim$2.6M). Total trainable: $\sim$367M. Host model (4B): fully frozen.

C Mind Tree Schema Specification

The Mind Tree uses a hierarchical XML schema with typed nodes. Each belief node carries: categorical conviction (`strong`/`moderate`/`agnostic`), domain tags, `addresses` (query types the node answers), `novel` flag (content unlikely to survive compilation), and `salience` (compilation priority). Example:

```
<belief id="b1" conviction="strong" domain="economics">
  UBI reduces poverty without reducing employment
  <argument id="a1" type="empirical" strength="strong"
            addresses="query:research,objection:laziness">
    Every controlled trial shows maintained employment
    <evidence source="Manitoba Mincome 1974-79" novel="true">
      8.5% hospitalization drop, no employment reduction
    </evidence>
  </argument>
</belief>
```

M only processes abstract nodes (beliefs, strategies, memories, models). Evidence, tactics, and details are *never* sent to M—they are selected deterministically based on which parent node M activated, via the `addresses` and `novel` properties.

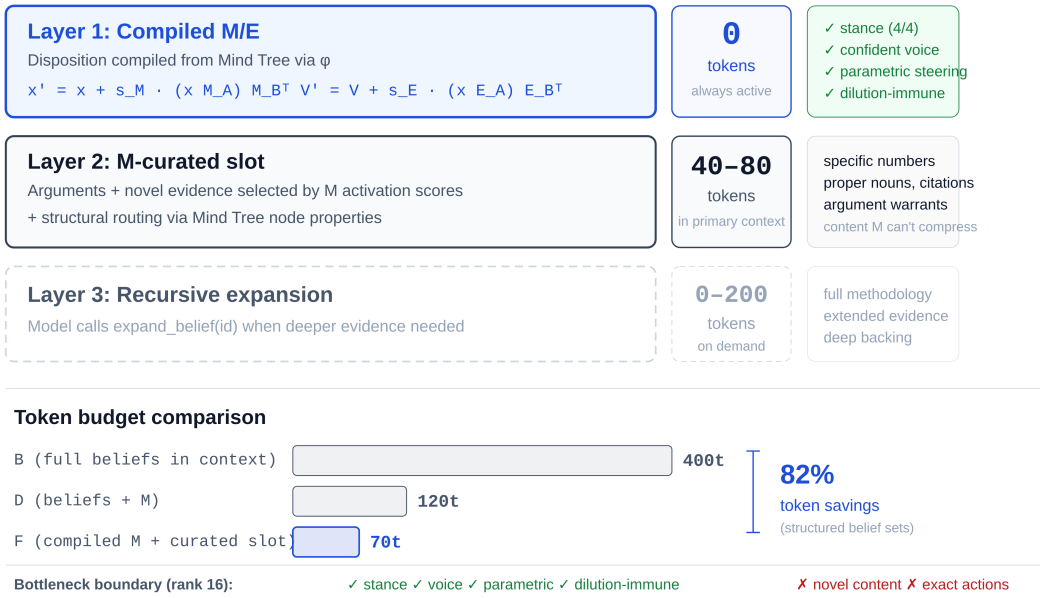

Figure 4: Three-layer architecture. Layer 1 (compiled M/E) provides zero-token dispositional conditioning that is dilution-immune by construction. Layer 2 (M-curated slot) injects 40–80 tokens of novel content that cannot survive the rank-16 bottleneck. Layer 3 (recursive expansion) provides deep evidence on demand via tool call. Total: 82% token savings over full beliefs in context.

D Architecture Evolution

v5–v6: Write Function Discovery. Initial Q-modulation with contrastive loss. Write function collapse (all M-states identical) resolved by higher $\lambda_{\text{contrast}}$ + more epochs. Key finding: NTP and contrastive objectives are compatible given sufficient training.

v7–v7.1: Coupled M-E and Norm Regulation (1.5B). Added V-modulation via coupled write functions with cross-modulation gates (init bias $= -5.0$). v7.1 introduced global norm regulation + E-attenuation, fixing multi-turn M-norm degeneration. Result: 87.5% held-out generalization, M-norms stable at 5.9 (under 6.5 ceiling).

v9–v11: Scaling to 30B (Qwen3-30B-A3B). Discovered Q-delta collapse: parameters separate in parameter space but produce identical functional perturbations. Functional contrastive loss on actual ΔQ tensors: F-sim $0.998 \rightarrow 0.029$ in 200 epochs.

v13–v14: Episodic Memory and Causal Necessity. Content-addressable episodic memory (100% retrieval, 35 memories) revealed the epiphenomenal memory problem: perfect metrics, zero generation effect. Causal necessity training ($\mathcal{L}_{\text{div}} + \mathcal{L}_{\text{coh}} + \mathcal{L}_{\text{fprint}}$) produced $10.5\times$ larger NTP gap.

v15–v21: Dispositions and Content Encoding (4B). Moved to Qwen3.5-4B-Base. 174-topic curriculum with conviction calibration. F-sim collapse (0.999) confirmed M is a universal style modulator, not topic-specific—content differentiation comes from beliefs in context.

v23: Compiled V-Modulation and Three-Layer Architecture. VModulationProjector enables zero-token belief compilation. Sycophancy gold training (44 responses from Claude Sonnet 4.6) fixes verbatim repetition. Three-layer architecture achieves 82% token savings.

E Adaptation Method Comparison

F Synthetic Task: User Preference Recall

[STUB — Migrate from current experiments.tex §5.1: 50 users, 2 binary preferences, Session 1/2 protocol, 100% Session 2 accuracy, 4-block M-state structure]

Table 1: Adaptation Method Comparison — All Costs in O-Notation

d = model dim, r = rank, L = layers, N = memory tokens in context, T = generated tokens, A = adaptations, M = model updates, $|D|$ = training data, $|C|$ = contrastive set, P = prefix length.

Method	Train cost (new base model)	Train cost (new adaptation)	Total training scaling	Inference overhead (per generated token)	Extra VRAM (at inference)	Adaptive	Outside context
LoRA (merged)	$O(M \cdot A \cdot \text{epochs})$	$O(\text{epochs} \cdot \lvert D \rvert)$	$O(M \times A)$	$O(0)$ absorbed into weights	$O(0)$ no extra	✗	✓
LoRA (hot-swap)	$O(M \cdot A \cdot \text{epochs})$	$O(\text{epochs} \cdot \lvert D \rvert)$	$O(M \times A)$	$O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ per token per layer	$O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ ~50MB/adapter	✗	✓
Adapters	$O(M \cdot A \cdot \text{epochs})$	$O(\text{epochs} \cdot \lvert D \rvert)$	$O(M \times A)$	$O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ FFN per layer	$O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ adapter params	✗	✓
Prefix Tuning	$O(M \cdot A \cdot \text{epochs})$	$O(\text{epochs} \cdot \lvert D \rvert)$	$O(M \times A)$	$O(L \cdot P \cdot d)$ attn over P prefix tokens	$O(L \cdot P \cdot d)$ prefix KV cache	✗	✗
RAG	$O(0)$	$O(0)$	$O(1)$	$O(T \cdot N \cdot d)$ attn over N retrieved tokens	$O(N \cdot L \cdot d)$ KV cache grows with N	✓	✗
Reflexion	$O(0)$	$O(0)$	$O(1)$	$O(T \cdot N \cdot d)$ grows with reflections	$O(N \cdot L \cdot d)$ unbounded growth	✓	✗
System Prompt	$O(0)$	$O(0)$	$O(1)$	$O(T \cdot N \cdot d)$ prompt tokens in attn	$O(N \cdot L \cdot d)$ KV cache	✓	✗
RepEng / ActAdd	$O(\lvert C \rvert \cdot \text{fwd})$ extract from contrastive set	$O(0)$ fixed direction	$O(M)$	$O(L \cdot d)$ one vector add/layer	$O(L \cdot d)$ ~10KB	✗	✓
Enmeshed (HEXIS)	$O(\text{epochs} \cdot \lvert D \rvert)$ train φ once	$O(1 \text{ fwd pass})$ compile beliefs → tensors	$O(M+A)$	$O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ 2 matmuls/layer, FIXED	$O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$ ~50KB, FIXED	✓	✓

Key comparison: Context methods (RAG, Reflexion) have **$O(T \cdot N \cdot d)$** inference cost — it grows with both generated tokens and memory size. Enmeshed networks have **$O(T \cdot L \cdot d \cdot r)$** — constant in memory size N. 100 beliefs or 10,000 beliefs: same inference cost.

Scaling example: 100 personas, Qwen 4B → 8B upgrade.

LoRA: retrain 100 adapters — O(100·epochs) | **HEXIS: retrain φ once + 100 fwd passes — O(1·epochs + 100)** | **RAG: O(0) training — but O(N) per token forever**

Weight modification | Context injection | Activation steering | Enmeshed network

Figure 5: Adaptation method comparison with all costs in O-notation. Enmeshed networks uniquely combine inference-cost adaptation ($O(1)$ forward pass per new belief set), fixed per-token overhead ($O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$, independent of memory size N), and operation outside the context window.

G Implicit Memory Validation

Priming. HEXIS: JSD = 0.0486 between different-preference users. Baseline: 0.0000. Layer 0, Head 2: JSD = 0.184. Up to 49.2° angular displacement.

Non-Reportability. Linear probe with M active: 100%. With M zeroed: 22% (below chance at 25%).

Dissociation. $2 \times 2 \times 2$ factorial (Memory System $\times$ Dilution $\times$ Format). M-state immune to dilution; system prompt degrades $8\times$.

H Generation Examples

[STUB — Pull from paper_examples.json: full outputs for all 5 conditions (A/B/C/D/F) on sample topics]

I Curation Ablation

[STUB — M-curated vs conviction-based vs random vs first-k slot selection]

J ALFWorld Detailed Results

[STUB — Per-task-type breakdown, strategy examples, curation pipeline details]

K Multi-Turn Attractor Problem

[STUB — Diagnosis: constant M $\rightarrow$ M-shaped tokens accumulate in KV cache $\rightarrow$ positive feedback. Mitigation: prefill-off gating, phase-gated application. Results.]

L Credence Sensitivity: A Negative Result

Numeric credences (0.82, 0.45) failed as an M-state feature across 7 training approaches: NTP with credence perturbation, GRPO (fresh and warm-start), SFT on gold responses, contrastive credence pairs, and two curriculum variants. Root cause: tokenizer represents "0.82" and "0.45" as similar digit sequences; the hidden state difference is far smaller than between categorical tokens "strong" and "agnostic". This is a representation bottleneck, not a training signal problem.

M Scale Validation (27B)

[STUB — v22.2 results on Qwen3.5-27B. Think-mode: A=4/4, B=4/4, D=0/4. F-sim collapse at 27B. V-mod not yet trained.]

N Enmeshed Network Design Space

We validate one point in a six-axis design space. Key unexplored directions:

Gated blending (Level 2). $h' = h + g(h) \odot f(h, M)$. A learned gate g could solve the multi-turn attractor by learning when to suppress M—e.g., reducing modulation during conversational turns while maintaining it during identity-establishing moments.

Cross-attention (Level 3). $h' = h + \text{Attn}(h, M, M)$. Treats M as a specialized expert with attention as the implicit router. Could transfer richer content through the bottleneck but at higher computational cost ($O(L \cdot d^2)$ vs. $O(L \cdot d \cdot r)$).

Adaptive rank allocation. More capacity at layers where M's empirical perturbation magnitude is largest. Layer activity analysis shows bimodal distribution—some layers are consistently more active, suggesting non-uniform rank could optimize the capacity-cost tradeoff.

Temporal profiles. Decay, oscillation, or phase-gated M strength over generation steps. Constant M (this work) produces the attractor problem; a learned temporal profile could provide strong identity establishment followed by natural conversational engagement.

Zone-aware modulation. Different M scaling for belief zones vs. evidence zones vs. query zones within the context. Designed but not validated—preliminary experiments showed no significant effect over uniform scaling.

Property graph backend. The Mind Tree's hierarchical structure maps naturally to a property graph database with vector-indexed nodes, enabling multi-hop traversal, temporal belief tracking, and similarity-based discovery at scale beyond XML serialization.

O Loose Ends and Dead Ends

This section documents the research narrative—what we tried, what failed, and why—in the spirit of honest reporting that we hope saves other researchers time.

Q-delta collapse (v10). Contrastive loss on flattened M parameters pushed them apart (cosine sim 0.18–0.35) but the functional deltas $x \cdot M_A \cdot M_B^\top$ remained identical (cosine sim 0.9999). The hidden state x dominates the product, washing out parameter-space differences. Functional contrastive loss on ΔQ directly was the fix.

Epiphenomenal memory (v13.8). The most surprising failure: 100% retrieval accuracy, 100% NTP wins, 0.508 nats improvement, measurable Q-perturbation (22% magnitude, 28° rotation)—and zero visible effect on generation. The model routed around M through the residual stream. This motivated causal necessity training (v14).

The permission hypothesis. M alone produces near-zero experiential output (3% on the 4-condition benchmark). A system prompt alone produces generic hallucinations (43%). Together: 93%. M provides content; the system prompt provides "permission" to express it. This synergy was not designed—it emerged from the 4-condition factorial.

Credence sensitivity. Seven distinct training approaches failed to induce sensitivity to numeric credences (0.82 vs 0.45). The tokenizer representation bottleneck is fundamental: digit sequences are too similar in embedding space. Categorical labels (strong/moderate/agnostic) work because they use semantically distinct tokens.

Bidirectional belief attention. Allowing bidirectional attention within belief XML zones (while maintaining causal attention elsewhere) showed no significant effect. The model already attends well to beliefs with standard causal masking.

Zone-aware M scaling. Applying different M magnitudes to belief zones vs. evidence zones vs. query zones showed no improvement over uniform M application. The rank-16 bottleneck appears to be the binding constraint, not zone-specific magnitude.

Compiled M for action selection. Q/V modulation during ALFWorld generation hurts constrained action selection (-13 percentage points). M shifts token probabilities away from the exact

action strings required. For constrained tasks, M's value is curation (selecting which strategies to put in context), not modulation.

Environment-dependent PPL wins (v7.1). The v7.1 checkpoint achieved 12/12 PPL wins only in the original training environment (Python 3.11 + older transformers). In a newer environment (Python 3.13 + transformers 4.56), base model forward pass produced different hidden states, breaking phi-base alignment. Lesson: pin your environment or expect to retrain phi.

P Reproducibility

Base model: Qwen3.5-4B-Base (HuggingFace). Training compute: single 24GB GPU, $\sim$10 hours total across all phases. Checkpoints and code will be released upon acceptance.

Key hyperparameters: rank $r = 16$, stride 3 (11 of 32 layers patched), $d = 2560$, max norm 1.5, belief window 512 tokens, v_scale 1.0. Phase A: lr 10^{-4}, margins 0.1–0.3. Phase B: lr 3×10^{-4}, margin 1.0. Phase D: lr 3×10^{-5}, 44 gold responses.